

Our forefathers used it in telegrams. Back when sending telegrams was charged per character, they'd try to squeeze up characters to form another word which could easily be related to the word that it was meant to replace – much the same way we abbreviate text messages today.

But does that hide the message? Not at all. After all, you did understand the first sentence of this chapter, didn't you? So did the cipher fail to do its job? Well, no, it didn't; it wasn't a cipher at all. It was a code.

Codes

History is full of stories of encryption. It doesn't matter if you're a fan of Sir Arthur Conan Doyle or Dan Brown or think you were a World War II hero in your past life, the fact that you're reading this generates a high probability that you already know about ciphers to some extent.

If you refer to day-to-day references, you can easily alter your focus and blur the line between codes and ciphers, seeing them as one and that wouldn't be all that wrong. Changing the names of your friends to "Vampire", "Sun" and "Scooter" is a common practice among those who want to hide the numbers of their friends from other unwanted users by confusing them. If you've used such a technique, chances are that you would recommend it to close friends as well.

But were you actually successful in keeping the identities hidden? Maybe, maybe not! Let's assume that you actually have those names in your phone's address book. What are the chances someone else could understand what "Vampire", "Sun" and "Scooter" stood for? If you're a fan of the (in)famous "Twilight" series of books, Vampire could be a very special friend. If you have a friend who eats a lot of non-vegetarian food you might use the same name for him. If your friend's real name is Sunny, 'Sun' would obviously be in reference to him. Scooter too, in the same manner can be related to someone with that nickname which stuck with them due to an incident, or maybe it was an accidental pet name you discovered in childhood.

The question that remains unanswered is "What's the probability that someone else could understand it?" If you paid attention, you'd notice that all the names were changed based on the real life experiences. Obviously then, close friends/family would be curious to know which name in your phonebook referred to which friend, and if they were good enough sleuths, they'd figure it out.

Now, let's get into the technicality of the subject and bring up a few terms. While we won't talk about "plaintext" and "ciphertext" again, it's